
FOR TEAM LEADS AND HIRING MANAGERS

The GovCon Onboarding Playbook

How to get a new hire fluent in defense acquisition in 30 days, instead of letting them absorb it by osmosis over the better part of a year. A week-by-week plan, the checklists, a ten-question Day 30 check and a learning path for every role.



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Osmosis is not an onboarding plan

We've all watched it happen. A sharp new hire joins a GovCon (government contracting) team, sits in meetings they only half follow, reads contracts they can't quite parse, and slowly pieces together how the Department of Defense (DoD) buys things. It works, eventually. So does learning to swim by falling off the dock.

Osmosis is slow. It's inconsistent, because it depends on who the new hire happens to sit next to. And it's expensive, though the time is the cheap part of the bill.

The expensive part: avoidable mistakes

MONEY

The wrong color of money

A funding document that cites the wrong appropriation. Research, development, test and evaluation (RDT&E) money, operation and maintenance (O&M) money and procurement money each buy different things, and the law cares which is which.

CONTRACTS

Vehicle or task order?

Mixing up the IDIQ (indefinite delivery, indefinite quantity) vehicle with the task order under it, then quoting the wrong scope, ceiling or deliverable to the customer.

AUTHORITY

The wrong person said yes

Starting new work because someone without contractual authority asked for it. That is how unauthorized commitments happen, and how invoices end up in a dispute.

Each one chips away at customer trust and creates real compliance risk. None of them needs a bad hire. They only need nobody to have explained the rules early.

WHAT A STRUCTURED 30 DAYS CHANGES

- Fewer mistakes in the first 90 days.
- Better proposal quality from day one.
- Faster contribution to program execution.
- A repeatable process, not a one-time lucky hire.

Who this is for

Team leads, program directors and hiring managers who want one repeatable way to bring new program managers (PMs), business development (BD) staff, capture managers and analysts up to speed on DoD acquisition, quickly and the same way every time.

How it works

You run a week-by-week framework. The new hire takes Acqlerate's short, self-paced lessons alongside it. The goal is practical fluency, meaning they can use what they learned on a real program, not just compliance awareness that evaporates after the training certificate is filed.

Your part as the lead fits on a sticky note: a program briefing on day 1, a check-in at day 14, a debrief at day 21 and a sign-off at day 30.

30

days from "just hired" to working without a chaperone

3

phases: learn it, use it, own it

4

touchpoints for you, the lead

10

questions in the Day 30 check that signs them off

Learn it, use it, own it

The plan runs in three phases, and each one builds on the last: foundational knowledge first, then hands-on application, then independent operation. It's how most of us learned to drive. The manual, then an empty parking lot, then the highway with you riding shotgun.



Days 1 to 14: understand the landscape

The first two weeks build a shared vocabulary and a baseline. Nobody needs to quote the Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR) by day 14. They do need to stop nodding politely every time someone says "task order" or "color of money" and hoping nobody asks a follow-up question. Four topics get them there.

TOPIC 1

What is DoD acquisition?

- The acquisition lifecycle, from requirement to award to execution.
- The key players: the PM, the contracting officer (CO), the contracting officer's representative (COR) and the Defense Contract Management Agency (DCMA).
- Common contract types: firm fixed price (FFP), cost plus fixed fee (CPFF), time and materials (T&M), and IDIQ.

TOPIC 2

How does the government buy?

- Standalone contracts vs. task orders.
- IDIQ vehicles and the fair opportunity process for competing orders.
- The FAR, which is being rewritten under the Revolutionary FAR Overhaul (RFO). Same name, new text, some new clause numbers.

TOPIC 3

What is color of money?

- Appropriation categories: RDT&E, O&M and procurement.
- Fiscal year rules: O&M can be put on contract for 1 year, RDT&E for 2, procurement for 3.
- Why Antideficiency Act (ADA) violations matter.

TOPIC 4

The three career tracks

- Government PM: owns cost, schedule and performance for the program.
- Contractor PM: delivers the work, and the margin.
- Contracting officer: the only one who can sign or change the contract.
- Different roles, different authorities, different incentives.

RECOMMENDED MODULES

DoD Acquisitions Foundations (Module 1, free) plus **Defense Contracting Fundamentals**. About 6.5 hours of lessons in total, so roughly 40 minutes a workday across the two weeks. Module 1 includes the lesson on working while the FAR is being rewritten.

Day 1 checklist

- ☐ Create a free Acqlerate account at acqclerate.com.
- ☐ Finish the first Foundations lesson.
- ☐ Read the Acquisition Starter Kit (Contractor or Government edition, also free).
- ☐ Program context briefing with the PM or program lead.
- ☐ Review the contract or task order they'll work under. The real one, not the slide that summarizes it.

By day 14

- ☐ Foundations module complete and Starter Kit read (aim for day 7).
- ☐ Defense Contracting Fundamentals complete.
- ☐ Contract reviewed, with a written list of questions.
- ☐ Day 14 check-in with you: what's clear, what's still fog.

Days 15 to 21: apply it to your program

Week 3 is where it stops being a course. The vocabulary from weeks 1 and 2 meets your actual contract, your actual customer, and that one deliverable that is somehow always late. The new hire shifts from learning to doing.

Four things to do this week

- 1 **Shadow one real activity.** A contract review, a program review or a proposal session. Watching a concept land in a live meeting beats reading about it three times.
- 2 **Complete the module that fits the role.** BD and capture staff take Capture Management & Business Development. PMs take Defense Finance & Budgeting or Data Analytics for Program Managers.
- 3 **Name one concept they still can't explain, and fix it.** The AI Study Assistant inside each Acqlerate lesson will explain it more simply or show how it applies on the job. Then have them explain it to you in two minutes. If they can teach it, they know it.
- 4 **Review their first CDRL (Contract Data Requirements List) or deliverable requirement.** The CDRL says what is due, in what format, to whom and how often. Somebody on the customer side is counting on it.

Role-specific guidance

CONTRACTOR PM

Know the contract cold

- Focus on Defense Contracting Fundamentals.
- Learn EVM (earned value management) basics: planned work, work done and what it cost.
- Know your task order SOW inside and out.

BD / CAPTURE

Write to the scorecard

- Complete Capture Management & Business Development.
- Understand Section L (instructions to offerors) vs. Section M (evaluation criteria).
- L tells you how to write it. M tells you how it gets scored. Evaluators score against M.

PROPOSAL ANALYST

Learn how proposals are judged

- Work through your pricing volume checklist.
- Study your past performance template.
- Learn source selection basics: how the government evaluates and picks a winner.

MAKE THE SHADOW SEAT COUNT

Spend five minutes before the meeting on what it's for, who's who and what to listen for. Spend five minutes after on what surprised them. With a briefing and a debrief, a meeting is a lesson. Without them it's just another meeting, and new hires already have plenty of those.

DAY 21 MILESTONE

Role-specific module done and first deliverable reviewed. Hold the day 21 debrief: what they saw in the shadow seat, what the CDRL asks for, and which concept they fixed this week. Anything still foggy goes on the list for week 4.

Days 22 to 30: operate independently

By the end of week 4 the new hire works with minimal hand-holding. Not zero. Nobody is fully independent at day 30, including a few people who've been on the program for ten years. Here is what "ready" looks like.

Ready means they can

- ☐ Describe the acquisition lifecycle in plain English, from requirements to award to execution.
- ☐ Explain what type of contract their program uses, and why it matters for risk and billing.
- ☐ Name the CO, COR and DCMA representative on their program, and say what each one controls.
- ☐ Say what color of money funds their program and the fiscal year limits that come with it.
- ☐ Identify two or three risks on their program and how each is being mitigated. Bonus points for putting a likelihood and a dollar value on each, the way a risk and opportunity register (R&O) does.

THE ASSESSMENT

Run the ten-question Day 30 check on the next page. It covers the acquisition lifecycle, contract types, color of money, and roles and authorities. If they pass, they're ready to contribute independently. If not, each miss points to a specific lesson to revisit, so you're fixing gaps, not repeating the whole month.

The 30-day milestones at a glance

DAY	MILESTONE	VERIFIED BY
Day 1	Acqlerate account created, first lesson complete	They show you their progress dashboard
Day 7	Foundations module complete, Starter Kit read	Module certificate
Day 14	Defense Contracting Fundamentals complete, contract reviewed	Team lead check-in
Day 21	Role-specific module done, first deliverable reviewed	Module certificate and debrief
Day 30	Day 30 check passed, operating independently	Check result and PM sign-off

An Acqlerate module certificate is issued only when every lesson in the module is finished. Each one carries an ID you can check at acqclerate.com/verify, which saves you from taking "yeah, I finished it" on faith.

WEEK 4 ASSIGNMENTS THAT BUILD INDEPENDENCE

Give them one task they own end to end, such as drafting a status report, updating a deliverable tracker or preparing their section of a review. Ask them to bring the two or three risks they found to your next team meeting. Owning something small beats observing something big.

Ten questions, one coffee, no slides

Sit down with the new hire for about twenty minutes, notes closed. Ask every question about **your** program, not in the abstract. You're not grading trivia. You're checking whether they can hold their own when you're not in the room.

#	ASK THEM	A GOOD ANSWER INCLUDES
1	Walk me through how our program got from a need to a contract. LIFECYCLE	A requirement, money in a budget, a solicitation, an award, then execution. In that order, in plain English.
2	Where is our program in its lifecycle today, and what's the next big event? LIFECYCLE	The current phase, plus the next option exercise, milestone, review or recompetes, and roughly when.
3	What type of contract are we on? CONTRACT TYPE	The type (FFP, CPFF, T&M or a mix) and whether it's a standalone contract or a task order under an IDIQ.
4	Who carries the cost risk on our contract, and how do we bill? CONTRACT TYPE	FFP: the contractor carries it and bills the agreed price. Cost-type: allowable costs reimbursed, plus fee. T&M: hours at fixed rates, plus materials.
5	What's the difference between the IDIQ and our task order? CONTRACT TYPE	The vehicle sets the ceiling and general terms. The order sets our scope, funding and deliverables, and it governs our work.
6	What color of money funds our work, and when does it expire? MONEY	The appropriation by name and how long it can be put on contract: O&M 1 year, RDT&E 2, procurement 3.
7	Why can't the customer just use leftover O&M money for our development work? MONEY	Each appropriation buys only what it was appropriated for. Using the wrong one can become an Antideficiency Act violation.
8	Who are our CO, COR and DCMA representative, and what does each one control? ROLES	Names, plus: the CO signs and changes the contract, the COR monitors performance, DCMA oversees contractor performance and administers contracts.
9	Someone on the customer side asks for work you don't see in the SOW. What do you do? ROLES	"Let me check with the CO," routed through our contracts lead. No work starts on a handshake.
10	What are the top two or three risks on our program, and who's working each one? RISK	Specific risks, a mitigation and an owner for each. Strong answers add a likelihood and a dollar value.

SCORING IT

Eight or more solid answers: they're ready, so sign them off. Fewer than eight: each miss points to a lesson. Assign it, then ask only those questions again a week later.

A SECOND DATA POINT

Every Acqlerate module ends with an assessment that unlocks the next depth level. Passed assessments plus a good Day 30 conversation is a sign-off you can defend.

Head these off in the first 30 days

These five come up again and again with new GovCon hires. Catch them in the first month and you save months of course correction, and at least one awkward call with the customer.

1 Skipping the contract review

The SOW tells you what's actually authorized. Everything you do on a government contract traces back to it: scope, deliverables, period of performance and funding. If you haven't read it, you're guessing. Confidently, and in front of the customer.

Do instead: read it before week 1 ends, and keep a one-page note of scope, deliverables, period of performance and funding where you can find it in a meeting.

2 Confusing the IDIQ with the task order

The vehicle gets you in the door. The task order is your actual contract. Think of the IDIQ as the restaurant menu: it sets the ceiling and the general terms. The task order is what was actually ordered, and it's the only thing anyone is paying for. It defines your specific scope, funding and deliverables.

Do instead: know which one governs your work. When someone quotes a ceiling or a requirement, ask "the vehicle's or the order's?"

3 Ignoring color of money

Appropriations work like gift cards: the coffee shop card doesn't work at the hardware store, however much is left on it. Using O&M money for work that should be RDT&E can become an Antideficiency Act violation. These categories aren't bureaucratic trivia. They're legal limits, and the consequences are personal for the officials involved.

Do instead: know the difference, know which color funds your work, and know when it expires.

4 Treating the COR like a boss

The COR monitors performance. Only the CO can change your contract. The COR checks your work against the blueprint, but only the CO can change the blueprint. Work started because someone without that authority asked for it rests on an unauthorized commitment, and you may never get paid for it.

Do instead: when anyone other than the CO asks for a change, however reasonable and however senior, the answer is "Let me check with the CO."

5 Assuming WarU training equals operational fluency

Compliance training and practical fluency are different things. Courses from WarU (Warfighting Acquisition University, called Defense Acquisition University or DAU until November 2025) cover policy and regulation. Knowing the rules of the road and merging onto the highway at rush hour are related skills. They are not the same skill.

Do instead: build both. Use WarU for the policy and regulation, and Acqlerate for the practical judgment to apply it in real contract and program situations.

Everyone starts in the same place, then the paths split

Every role starts with **DoD Acquisitions Foundations** (Module 1). It's free, and it gives the whole team one shared vocabulary, which ends a surprising number of meeting arguments. From there, each role takes the path it needs most.

ROLE	MODULES, IN ORDER	LESSON TIME	AFTER DAY 30, GO DEEPER WITH
Contractor PM	Foundations, Contracts, Finance, Data, Operations	About 15.5 hours	The Business of Defense Contracting
BD / Capture	Foundations, Capture, Contracts	About 8 hours	Small Business in Defense Contracting
Proposal analyst	Foundations, Capture, Contracts	About 8 hours	From Need to RFP: The Government Pre-Award Process
Contracts manager or CO	Foundations, Contracts, Finance	About 11 hours	The Compliance Stack
Financial analyst	Foundations, Finance, Data	About 9.5 hours	The Business of Defense Contracting

RFP: request for proposal. Lesson time is the total of the listed modules' lessons. New hire just out of uniform? Add Veteran Transition: From Uniform to Acquisition. Joining a startup or a non-traditional supplier? Add The Startup On-Ramp.

HOW TO USE THIS TABLE

Start every new hire on Foundations. It's free and takes about 2.5 hours. Then assign the role path. Most people finish their track inside the 30 days alongside everything else onboarding throws at them: even the longest, at about 15.5 hours, is roughly 40 minutes a workday. Check progress at your weekly check-in on their dashboard, and use the module certificates as your record.

What the six core modules cover

DoD Acquisitions Foundations (free). The acquisition lifecycle, key players, contract types and career paths, plus working while the FAR is rewritten. The shared language every team member needs.

Defense Contracting Fundamentals. IDIQ vehicles, task orders, FAR essentials, reading a SOW, source selection, CDRLs, contract administration, modifications and unauthorized commitments.

Defense Finance & Budgeting. Color of money, appropriations law, the budget cycle, EVM basics, estimates at completion, funding documents and staying on the right side of the Antideficiency Act.

Capture Management & Business Development. The capture process, competitive analysis, Section L and M, teaming agreements and building a win strategy.

Data Analytics for Program Managers. Program data analysis, reporting requirements, CDRLs, earned value reports and the performance metrics that tell you how a program is really doing.

Program Operations & Leadership. Day-to-day program execution, risk management, stakeholder communication, subcontractor oversight and government reporting.

Eight more modules go deeper once the basics stick, from small business rules and compliance to sustainment, closeout and the history behind the rules. 14 modules and 124 lessons in all.

Ready to build a sharper team?

Your team doesn't need another multi-day classroom course. They need a structured, self-paced path from "I just got hired" to "I understand how this program works." This playbook is the plan. Acqlerate is the training that runs inside it.

Free for every team member

- Module 1, DoD Acquisitions Foundations: 10 lessons, about 2.5 hours.
- Both editions of the Acquisition Starter Kit.
- 14 days of full access for every new account.
- No credit card. No approval chain. Create an account and start.

What full access adds

- All 14 modules and 124 lessons, each at three depth levels.
- Quizzes after every lesson and an assessment for each module, with progress tracking.
- The Debrief, an audio episode for each module, for the commute.
- A certificate for every finished module, with a verification ID.
- Team seats include the Acqlerate Coach, which grades how well your people can explain each lesson back.

The trial ends at day 14, halfway through this plan. For the role modules in weeks 3 and 4, the new hire needs a paid plan or a team seat. Details at acqlerate.com/teams.

START TODAY

Start any team member free at acqlerate.com. Sign-up takes about a minute.

NO SCHEDULING

No classroom dates to book. No per-seat contract negotiations. A lesson fits between meetings.

BUILT TO FINISH

Short lessons, a two-minute daily challenge, streaks and XP (experience points). Think Duolingo, for defense acquisition.

The short version of this whole playbook

- ☐ Weeks 1 and 2: Foundations and Contracting Fundamentals, the Starter Kit, the real contract.
- ☐ Week 3: a shadow seat, the role module, one fuzzy concept fixed, the first CDRL reviewed.
- ☐ Week 4: owned work, two or three risks named, the Day 30 check, your sign-off.

Start your next hire on Module 1. It's free.

Then share this playbook with whoever onboards the hire after that.

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Acqlerate is an independent training provider. It is not affiliated with or endorsed by DoD, WarU or any government agency, and this playbook is not official guidance. DoD has also used the name Department of War since September 2025; this playbook says DoD. Facts were checked in September 2026. Always confirm contract questions with your contracting officer and the current regulations.